



Squid, octopus, and cuttlefish

Most marine mollusks are simple animals; many seem to have only basic senses. But squid and their relatives—the cephalopods—are different. They are calculating, sharp-eyed hunters, with excellent memories. They have long, flexible arms and tentacles, and some amazing adaptations for hunting, swimming, defense, and communication.

COLORFUL CUTTLEFISH

Cuttlefish live in shallow coastal waters where they swim slowly over the seabed looking for crabs, shrimp, and other prey to catch with their long tentacles. Like many cephalopods, they have an amazing ability to change color—switching in a split second from camouflage to dazzling zebra stripes, and even flashing in moving waves of color like neon signs.

▼ SECRET WEAPON

This common cuttlefish shoots out its tentacles at lightning speed to seize a crab.



SHELLED NAUTILUS

Unlike other cephalopods, the nautilus has a coiled snail-like shell. The shell contains gas that makes it buoyant, enabling the nautilus to rise and sink in the water like a submarine. Nautiluses are found in the Indian and Pacific oceans, where they prey on other animals and scavenge the remains of dead ones. Nautiluses have lived in the oceans for about 500 million years—long before the time of the dinosaurs.

JET-PROPELLED SQUID

Unlike their cuttlefish and octopus relatives, most squid live in open water and travel in big schools. They are very streamlined, and able to streak through the water at high speed by blasting water out of their siphon tubes—a form of jet propulsion. Some may even shoot out of the water into the air.



▲ LOW-SPEED OPTION

To swim at slower speeds, this common squid ripples the fins at the back of its body.